

about 1,500 words

The Board at Pen Argyl
by Douglxss Burley Johnson

Hand me that poker, would you? This end of the fire's gone gray, and I want it going good before I tell this one, because in this one the fire ends up the most important thing in the yard.

I grew up in Pen Argyl, up in the Slate Belt, where the roofs are slate and half the old sidewalks are slate and the quarry holes sit back in the woods full of green water so deep nobody's ever touched bottom. In October of 2021 I was thirteen. We'd lost a whole year of Halloween to the virus, and that fall every kid in town wanted a party, so Tyler Morgan's mother said fine, the basement, and she'd be upstairs.

Kayleigh Hess came to that party. You need to know about Kayleigh first. Her brother Danny drowned in the Albion hole the July before, on a Sunday afternoon, jumping off the high ledge with his friends. He was seventeen. Three weeks before he died he got baptized at my church, in the big tank behind the pulpit, with his hair sticking straight up when he came out of the water and the whole room clapping. Afterward, out in the parking lot, he shook the water out

of his ear and told me and Kayleigh, "If anything ever happens to me, I'm with Jesus. You two know where I'll be." Kayleigh rolled her eyes at him. Danny always called her Bug.

So that was the girl who came down Tyler's basement stairs, around the laundry basket of folded towels his mother had left on the third step, in a black sweatshirt with cat ears clipped in her hair, and that was what she was carrying.

The basement smelled like a dehumidifier that needed emptying and the cheap pumpkin candle Tyler's mother had set on the dryer. There was a bowl of candy corn nobody touched and a TV playing an old monster movie with the sound off. Tyler's cousin Brandon was nineteen and home from somewhere, and he'd brought a talking board in a long flat box, the kind with the alphabet printed in an arch and a sun and a moon in the corners and a little plastic heart on three tiny pads.

"It's a game," Brandon said. "They sell it at Target."

Six of us sat around it on the carpet. I sat with my knees up and my back on the washing machine, and I'll tell you the truth, I didn't put my fingers on the heart, but I didn't leave either. I wanted to see. That's how it gets you. All it asks is that you stay.

For a while it was dumb. Brandon pushed it, you could tell, spelling out a girl's name, and everybody screamed and laughed. Then Brandon asked, "Is anybody here who wants to talk to somebody here?" in a spooky voice, and the heart went to YES and stopped hard, the way a shopping cart stops when one wheel catches.

Brandon took his hands off it. The heart stayed on YES. Then it moved again with only two girls' fingertips on it, and neither of those girls was pushing, because I could see their faces, and their faces had gone white as the candle.

B. U. G.

Kayleigh sat back on her heels.

Nobody in the world called her Bug but Danny. The two girls snatched their hands away, and the little heart slid on by itself, slow, across the slick board.

COLD. ALONE. IN THE WATER. COME SEE ME BUG.

Kayleigh's mouth opened. Her eyes filled up all at once, and she reached for the heart with both hands like she was reaching for a sleeve.

ALBION. MIDNIGHT. COME.

I want you to understand how fast it went. One minute it was a Halloween party with candy corn and a werewolf on the TV, and the next minute a grieving fourteen-year-old girl was getting invited to a quarry ledge at midnight by a voice that knew her brother's pet name. Brandon stood up and backed into the furnace. Somebody started crying. The candle on the dryer burned straight up, not a flicker, and the dehumidifier clicked off by itself.

My grandmother used to say the devil shows up with your name in his mouth. I hadn't understood her until that night.

What I understood right then was simpler. I'd been in that church parking lot with water dripping off Danny Hess's chin. I'd heard him say it. Danny wasn't cold, and he wasn't alone, and he wasn't in the water. Whatever was pushing that plastic heart around knew a nickname, and it lied about everything else.

My knees were shaking so bad I had to put my hand on the washing machine to get up. I said, "Kayleigh, don't touch it." My voice came out small. I made it bigger.

"Danny's with Jesus," I said. "You were standing right there when he told us. That's not Danny."

The heart jerked across the board to NO and back to BUG, BUG, BUG, fast, and the girls closest to it crawled backward on the carpet.

I didn't argue with it. My grandmother told me once you don't argue with it any more than you'd argue with a snake in the woodpile. I stepped over two kids and put my foot down flat on the board, sneaker and all, and I said, "In the name of Jesus Christ, you get out of this house and you leave her alone." I didn't say it pretty. I said it like you'd yell at a dog going for a baby.

The heart quit. It sat under the toe of my sneaker like any cheap piece of plastic. The candle flame bent over sideways and came back up. Upstairs, through the floor, we heard Tyler's mother's TV again, a game show and an audience clapping, and I couldn't have told you when we'd stopped hearing it.

Then I did the other thing my grandmother taught me, which is the part people skip. I took Kayleigh by the wrist and I ran. The Bible calls that fleeing, and there's no shame in it. I pulled her up those stairs past Tyler's mother in her bathrobe, out the side door, and into the cold yard, and we stood by the fire pit where Tyler's dad had a few logs going for the little kids, and Kayleigh shook so hard her cat ears fell off in the grass.

Tyler came out a minute later with the board under his arm and the plastic heart in his fist.

"What do I do with it," he said.

Tyler's dad looked at the board, and at Kayleigh, and at me, and he didn't ask a single question. He was a Slate Belt man who'd grown up in a church basement himself. He took the board from his son and broke it across his knee, and it cracked loud, like a shingle coming off a roof. He laid both halves on the logs. The printed sun and moon curled up brown and black, and

the alphabet went one letter at a time. Tyler tossed the heart in after it, and it melted down to a bubble and a smell.

Brandon stood on the porch with his hands in his hoodie and watched the whole thing and didn't say a word, and that was the right thing for him to say.

Kayleigh didn't go to the Albion hole that night. I slept over at her house, on the floor beside her bed with a flashlight. Her mother brought us cocoa in two mismatched mugs, one of them from the fire company carnival, and never asked why I'd come home with her daughter in the middle of a party. When the clock on her nightstand went past midnight we were both still awake, and I read her the part in Second Corinthians where Paul says that to be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord, and I read it twice because she asked me to. Around three she fell asleep holding the edge of my blanket.

That spring she started coming to church with me. She sat in the same row where she'd watched her brother go under the water. She never asked me what was talking through that board, and I never told her what I think. I'll tell you what I know. It knew one little word, and it used that word to try to walk a grieving girl to the edge of a quarry in the dark.

Kayleigh's a nurse now, up at the hospital in Easton. Neither one of us has touched one of those boards since.

Go on, throw that log on. Get it high. I like a fire in October that's just a fire, for warming hands and cooking hot dogs and lighting up faces, and nobody's calling anybody to come sit by it but us.

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